

“We do the necessary hardening before we use open source technologies”

The best way to check the security levels of any technology is to look at its implementation in sensitive sectors like BFSI, telecom, et al. And most marketers of proprietary software will be surprised to know that open source technology is doing pretty well in these sectors too. Kotak Mahindra Bank, earlier known as ING Vysya, is one such example. **Diksha P. Gupta** from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Ashwin Khorana, CTO, Kotak Mahindra Bank**, to discuss the bank's tryst with open source technology. And here's what we got to know...



Ashwin Khorana,
CTO, Kotak Mahindra Bank

Q What role does technology play in the day-to-day operations of your company?

We were earlier known as ING Vysya bank, but we have recently been acquired by Kotak. So we are now known as Kotak Mahindra Bank. Banking without technology is definitely not a possibility today. Technology is important to ensure that we remain continuously available in a manner in which there is complete trust from the people who are banking with us. So, technology is really mainstream for us. Technology and the products we offer go hand-in-hand. It's no longer about being a department in the background; it's about being a department in the forefront.

Q Is open source technology a part of the gamut of options you've chosen?

As ING Vysya Bank, our firm used to be a big user of open source technologies. In fact, the percentage of Linux boxes used in our organisation was very high. We believe in open source technologies and in exploiting them. So we did not restrict ourselves to just the operating system, which is Linux. We went on to use MySQL databases for our internal

efficiency systems. We also implemented an open source load balancer. Usually, load balancers come as an appliance from big companies. But before we jumped into buying one, we used an open source software load balancer for about 18 months. Eventually, we had to go for the appliance, because it is something that is customer facing and needs to work continuously. Hence, the investment was required to be done, and we did that. We also used Alfresco, which is again, a community edition software, for internal workloads. To top it all, our core banking solution ran on the GTM database, which is a proprietary open source database from Fidelity Information Systems (FIS). Our journey started off from this core banking database and it gave us confidence that things are moving in the desired direction with open source technology.

Q BFSI is one sector where security is of prime importance and there are government regulations to ensure the security of customers' data. Were there any inhibitions related to security when you started with open source technology? How did you convince your management about using this technology?

Anything that you buy from the market, whether it is open source or licensed software, comes with 'default settings'. If you don't hide that, then whether it is open source software or a licensed product, it is open to the community, and people can do what they want with it. So, whether we use a licensed product or open source software, we have our hardening policy in place, which will ensure that whatever we deploy in our environment is secure. Banks have something called operating system guidelines. For each component of technology that we use, we have to ensure that these guidelines are followed; there are a lot of activities that need to be carried out, before we say that the box is really ready for production. This practice ensures that the environment is secure. Whether it is about a database, an operating system or an appliance that we are trying to put in, we ensure that each product goes through this process